GARDEN CITY CHURCH

LIVE THE LIFE. TELL THE STORY.

LANGUAGE OF A LEADER

WELCOME

INTRODUCTION AND ORIENTATION

Welcome to Language of a Leader!
I am so grateful to have you join me for this transformative 8-week leadership curriculum. At Garden City Church, our mission is to "Live the Life. Tell the Story." To truly live out this mission, it is essential that we, as leaders, master the art of communication. The way we use language has the power to inspire, influence, and guide those we lead. We cannot effectively tell our story, if we do not value our language and communication.

Purpose of the Course
Like any good relationship, health is built on trust, and trust is navigated through communication. The primary goal of "Language of a Leader" is to develop the leaders of Garden City Church in their communication skills and their ability to convey the most important message through the means of language. Effective communication is not just about speaking; it's about ensuring that our words align with our mission and values, and that they resonate deeply with our audience.

Importance of Clarity
Clarity through language is a coveted and necessary skill for any leader. In a world filled with noise and distractions, clear and concise communication cuts through the chaos, bringing understanding and unity. When we communicate with clarity, we reduce misunderstandings, build trust, and create a strong foundation for effective ministry. Our ability to articulate our vision and values clearly will not only strengthen our leadership but also empower our community to live out the life and tell the story of Jesus Christ more effectively.

CURRICULUM STRUCTURE

1. **Opening Prayer and Devotion (10 minutes):** Start each session with prayer and a short devotion related to the week's principle.
2. **Lesson Introduction (15 minutes):** Introduce the biblical principle and key concepts.
3. **Teaching Session (30 minutes):** In-depth teaching with examples from scripture and external sources.
4. **Group Discussion (20 minutes):** Facilitate discussion questions and small group interactions.
5. **Practical Application (15 minutes):** Role-playing exercises and real-life application scenarios.
6. **Closing Reflection and Prayer (10 minutes):** Reflect on the lesson and close with prayer.

EXTERNAL SOURCES AND REFERENCES

1. Joyce Meyer - "Change Your Words, Change Your Life”
2. John Maxwell - "Everyone Communicates, Few Connect”
3. Andy Stanley - "Communicating for a Change”
4. Billy Graham - Various sermons and writings on integrity.
5. Stephen Covey - "The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People”
6. Rick Warren - "The Purpose Driven Church”
7. Joel Osteen - Various teachings on encouragement.

This curriculum aims to equip Charismatic and Pentecostal Christian leaders with the tools to communicate effectively, embodying the principles of clarity, grace, integrity, and influence in their leadership.

WEEK 1

UNDERSTANDING COMMUNICATION

The Power of Unified Communication

"And the LORD said, 'Behold, they are one people, and they have all one language, and this is only the beginning of what they will do. And nothing that they propose to do will now be impossible for them.'" ~Genesis 11:6 (ESV)

The story of the Tower of Babel highlights the power and potential of unified communication. When people speak the same language and work together, their capabilities are limitless. This underscores the importance of clear and effective communication within any community, including the church.

What is Communication?

At first glance, the question "What is communication?" might seem straightforward. However, communication is one of the most intricate and multifaceted concepts in human existence. It involves not just the exchange of words, but a complex interaction of various elements.

There are 195 countries in the world, but over 7,139 known languages, with more being discovered regularly. This number doesn't include the myriad of dialects, which are variations within a language. For example, the English language alone boasts over 150 dialects. This complexity is further compounded by the ways people personalize their language.

In Miami, English-speaking Latin Americans often blend Cuban-Spanish dialects with English, creating a unique regional form of English. Phillip M. Carter, Director of the Center for Humanities in an Urban Environment at Florida International University, explains, “In Miami, there are many ways of speaking English. The variety we have been studying for the past 10 years or so is the main language variety of people born in South Florida in Latinx-majority communities. The variety is characterized by some unique but ultimately minor pronunciations, some minor grammatical differences, and word differences, which are influenced by the longstanding presence of Spanish in South Florida” (David Landsel, Indy100.com).

The Complexity of Communication

Communication extends beyond words. It includes facial expressions, inflections, tone, sighs, and hand gestures. Our words are often influenced by thoughts, memories, emotions, childhood experiences, and both positive and negative experiences. Given the complexity of language, it's remarkable that people can interact effectively at all.

Communication in Christian Leadership

As Christian leaders, we are called to communicate the gospel with clarity and effectiveness. The Bible itself is a form of written communication. God spoke and communicated through His word. He raised up prophets and teachers to carry His message, and used object lessons and symbolism to convey His truths.

Today, the church communicates through preaching, teaching, singing, and living lives that demonstrate our faith in Jesus. At Garden City Church, one of our core values is excellence. This value is deeply connected to our communication. The Bible instructs us to pursue excellence in all things and reminds us that we are being perfected through Christ.

"And this is my prayer: that your love may abound more and more in knowledge and depth of insight, so that you may be able to discern what is best and may be pure and blameless for the day of Christ.” ~Philippians 1:9-10 (NIV)

"Whatever you do, work at it with all your heart, as working for the Lord, not for human masters, since you know that you will receive an inheritance from the Lord as a reward. It is the Lord Christ you are serving.” ~ Colossians 3:23-24 (NIV)

Nosce te Ipsum

One of the best-kept secrets among effective communicators is their practice of introspection. The Latin phrase "Nosce te ipsum," meaning "Know thyself," is a guiding principle for great communicators. They possess a deep understanding of their own insecurities, strengths, and contexts. This self-awareness is crucial, because it shapes the clarity and intentionality of their communication.

Self-Awareness in Communication

- **Insecurities:** Recognizing personal insecurities helps communicators manage and mitigate them, ensuring these insecurities do not hinder their message.
- **Strengths:** Understanding their strengths allows communicators to leverage them effectively, enhancing their ability to connect with their audience.
- **Contexts:** Being aware of their personal and cultural contexts enables communicators to tailor their messages appropriately, making them more relevant and impactful.

Great communicators know what they want to say, why they are saying it, and what they aim to achieve through their communication.

"The hearts of the wise make their mouths prudent, and their lips promote instruction." ~Proverbs 16:23 (NIV)

Starting with the End in Mind

Effective communicators, especially in the context of preaching, often begin with the end goal in mind. For instance, when preparing a sermon, the primary goal might be to lead souls to Christ. With this goal clearly identified, every word of the sermon is crafted to point towards that ultimate objective.

Example of Goal-Oriented Communication

- **End Goal:** A soul coming to Christ.
- **Message Crafting:** Every story, illustration, and Bible verse used in the sermon is chosen to support and drive towards this goal. The language is intentional, the points are clear, and the delivery is designed to inspire and move the audience towards making a decision for Christ.

"I press on toward the goal to win the prize for which God has called me heavenward in Christ Jesus." ~Philippians 3:14 (NIV)

Intentionality in Leadership

For one to be both an effective leader and great communicator, intentionality in words and speech is paramount. Great communicators do not have the bandwidth for foolish or wasted words. Every conversation, speech, and interaction is an opportunity to influence, inspire, and lead.

Practical Steps for Intentional Communication:

- **Clarity of Purpose:** Know the purpose of your communication. What do you want to achieve? What is the desired outcome?
  - "Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he." ~Proverbs 29:18 (KJV)
- **Audience Understanding:** Understand your audience. What are their needs, concerns, and contexts? Tailor your message to resonate with them.
  - "To the weak I became weak, to win the weak. I have become all things to all people so that by all possible means I might save some." ~1 Corinthians 9:22 (NIV)

- **Preparation and Practice:** Prepare thoroughly and practice your delivery. Rehearse your key points and anticipate possible questions or objections.
  - "Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a worker who does not need to be ashamed and who correctly handles the word of truth." ~ 2 Timothy 2:15 (NIV)
- **Feedback and Reflection:** Seek feedback on your communication and reflect on your performance. Identify areas for improvement and work on them consistently.
  - "Whoever heeds life-giving correction will be at home among the wise." ~Proverbs 15:31 (NIV)

KEY INGREDIENTS OF EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION

LISTENING: ACTIVELY PAYING ATTENTION

"My dear brothers and sisters, take note of this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak and slow to become angry." ~James 1:19 (NIV)

PRACTICAL STEPS

- **Practice Active Listening:** Focus on the speaker without interrupting. Nod, make eye contact, and use verbal affirmations like "I see" or "I understand."
- **Reflective Listening:** Paraphrase what the speaker has said to ensure you have understood correctly. For example, "So what you're saying is..."
- **Ask Questions:** Never assume to understand until you know you understand. Inquire for clarity and more details. This shows interest and helps deepen understanding.
  - Even as Spirit led believers, when the Holy Spirit reveals, confirmation is needed. In other words if the Holy Spirit tells you something about someone, you should confirm it by going to the person - when possible.
- **Avoid Distractions:** Put away your phone, make eye contact, avoid multitasking, and create an environment conducive to listening.

INTERNALIZATION: REFLECTING AND ABSORBING INFORMATION

"The beginning of wisdom is this: Get wisdom. Though it cost all you have, get understanding." ~Proverbs 4:7 (NIV)

PRACTICAL STEPS

- **Meditate on the Message:** After a conversation, take time to reflect on what was said. Consider how it aligns with your values and beliefs.
- **Journal Your Thoughts:** Write down key points and your reflections on them. This helps in processing and internalizing information.
- **Seek Understanding:** Don't just hear the words, but try to understand the underlying emotions and motivations.
- **Apply Insights:** Think of practical ways to apply the new knowledge or perspective in your daily life.

CONSIDERATION: THOUGHTFULLY CONSIDERING YOUR RESPONSE

"Do nothing out of selfish ambition or vain conceit. Rather, in humility value others above yourselves, not looking to your own interests but each of you to the interests of the others." ~Philippians 2:3-4 (NIV)

PRACTICAL STEPS

- **Pause Before Responding:** Take a moment to think before you speak. This helps in crafting a thoughtful and considerate response.
- **Empathize with Others:** Put yourself in the other person's shoes. Consider their feelings and viewpoints.
- **Avoid Judgment:** Approach conversations without preconceived notions. Be open to different perspectives. Commit to learning a new perspective, idea our point of view.
- **Be Mindful of Your Words:** Choose words that are kind, respectful, and encouraging.

RESPONDING: COMMUNICATING CLEARLY AND RESPECTFULLY

"Let your conversation be always full of grace, seasoned with salt, so that you may know how to answer everyone." ~Colossians 4:6 (NIV)

PRACTICAL STEPS

- **Be Clear and Concise**: Express your thoughts in a straightforward manner, avoiding unnecessary jargon or complexity.
- **Use "I" Statements:** Frame your responses with "I feel" or "I think" to express personal perspective without sounding accusatory.
- **Stay on Topic:** Address the matter at hand without digressing into unrelated subjects.
- **Provide Constructive Feedback:** When giving feedback, focus on the behavior and not the person. Offer solutions or suggestions

RESISTING (REACTIONS): CONTROLLING IMPULSIVE REACTIONS

"A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger."
~ Proverbs 15:1 (NIV)

PRACTICAL STEPS

- **Count to Ten:** If you feel the urge to react impulsively, count to ten before responding. This helps in calming down and thinking clearly.
- **Practice Deep Breathing:** Take a few deep breaths to center yourself before reacting.
- **Use Positive Self-Talk:** Remind yourself to stay calm and collected. Phrases like "Stay calm," "Be patient," and "Think it through" can be helpful.
- **Seek Clarification:** If something triggers you, ask for clarification instead of reacting immediately. This can prevent misunderstandings.

PATIENCE: EXERCISING PATIENCE IN CONVERSATIONS

"Be completely humble and gentle; be patient, bearing with one another in love."
~Ephesians 4:2 (NIV)

PRACTICAL STEPS

- **Slow Down:** Deliberately slow your pace of speaking and thinking during conversations.
- **Allow Silence:** Don't rush to fill every silence. Allow pauses for reflection and thought.
- **Practice Mindfulness:** Stay present in the moment without letting your mind wander to future responses or unrelated thoughts.
- **Acknowledge Your Feelings:** Recognize when you are feeling impatient and remind yourself of the importance of patience in communication.

The Mandate for Excellence in Communication

As we journey through this course, our goal is to enhance your ability to contribute positively to the culture of our community through your interactions. We aim to improve your preaching, teaching, and engagement with others.

"Do not let any unwholesome talk come out of your mouths, but only what is helpful for building others up according to their needs, that it may benefit those who listen." ~ Ephesians 4:29 (NIV)

Have you ever considered your biblical mandate to be an excellent communicator? Embracing this mandate can transform your leadership and ministry, allowing you to effectively convey the gospel and foster a healthy, thriving community.

WEEK 2

THE POWER OF WORDS

Biblical Principle

"The tongue has the power of life and death, and those who love it will eat its fruit." ~Proverbs 18:21

Introduction:

Recently, a middle school teacher sought to demonstrate the power of words. She placed two apples in brown paper bags on opposite corners of her classroom. Each morning for several days, she had her students gather around one bag and hurl insults at it. They would then surround the second bag and speak lovingly and compassionately to it, offering words of affirmation and affection. After several days, they opened the bags. The apple that had received insults was found to be rotten and mold-ridden. The apple that had received praise looked as fresh and crisp as day one. We often hear that our words have power, and we see this in Scripture, but how many believers truly believe it? And if we do not believe God's Word, can we actually call ourselves believers?

So, how much power do our words actually have? Are we able to manifest a reality through positive confession or bring sickness upon ourselves through negative repetition? The biblical answer is both yes and no. The Bible teaches us that we will eat the fruit of our words. When we speak Gods word, we will reap his blessings. When we speak words of the flesh or of the enemy we will reap carnality, sickness and death. Whose words do you speak?

FIVE BIBLICAL POINTS ON THE IMPACT OF WORDS

1. Words Can Build Up or Tear Down:
Ephesians 4:29 - "Do not let any unwholesome talk come out of your mouths, but only what is helpful for building others up according to their needs, that it may benefit those who listen."
Our words have the power to either edify or destroy. We must choose to speak words that build up and encourage others.

2. Words Reflect the Heart:
Matthew 12:34 - "For out of the abundance of the heart the mouth speaks."
The words we speak reveal the condition of our hearts. If our hearts are filled with love and kindness, our words will reflect that.

3. Words Can Bring Healing or Harm:
Proverbs 12:18 - "The words of the reckless pierce like swords, but the tongue of the wise brings healing."
Our words can either wound or heal. We should strive to speak words of wisdom and healing.

4. Words Have Eternal Consequences:
Matthew 12:36-37 - "But I tell you that everyone will have to give account on the day of judgment for every empty word they have spoken. For by your words you will be acquitted, and by your words you will be condemned."
Our words have eternal significance. We will be held accountable for what we say, so we must speak wisely.

5. Words Can Influence Faith:
Romans 10:17 - "Consequently, faith comes from hearing the message, and the message is heard through the word about Christ."
Words can build faith. Speaking the truth of God's Word can strengthen our faith and the faith of others.

KEY CONCEPTS

- **Understanding the Weight and Impact of Words**
  - The words we speak carry significant weight and can have profound effects on our lives and the lives of others.
- **Speaking Life and Encouragement**
  - We should strive to speak words that bring life, hope, and encouragement to those around us.

OBJECT LESSONS

- **Planting Seeds**
  - Use seeds and soil to demonstrate how words can plant either positive or negative seeds in someone's life. Nurturing positive seeds leads to growth and fruitfulness, while negative seeds can stunt growth.
- **Mirror Reflection**
  - Have participants look into a mirror and speak positive affirmations to themselves. Discuss how speaking kindly to oneself can boost self-esteem and confidence.
- **Paper and Scissors**
  - Give each participant a piece of paper and scissors. Have them cut the paper into pieces, symbolizing hurtful words. Then, ask them to try to piece the paper back together, showing how difficult it is to repair the damage done by negative words.

TECHNIQUES

- **Thoughtful Speech**
  - Encourage participants to pause and think before they speak. Use a three-second rule: before saying something, count to three and consider if the words are true, kind, and necessary.
- **Positive Reinforcement**
  - Practice using affirming language in everyday conversations. Create scenarios where participants must respond to various situations with positive, encouraging words.

ACTIVITY

Compliment Circle

Form a circle and have each participant give a genuine compliment to the person next to them. This exercise helps practice giving and receiving positive reinforcement.

"Be careful with your words, once they are are said, they can only be forgiven, not forgotten."
- Carl Sandburg

WEEK 3

CLARITY IN COMMUNICATION

Biblical Principle

"Again, if the trumpet does not sound a clear call, who will get ready for battle? So it is with you. Unless you speak intelligible words with your tongue, how will anyone know what you are saying?" ~ 1 Corinthians 14:8-9

Introduction

Two teens found themselves in a heated texting fight. Words were being shot back and forth at a rapid pace. So quickly were the responses, one would wonder if either stopped to truly read each other's texts. Finally, one of the parents, noticing how flustered the other was, jumped in to inquire. As the teen began to explain, an issue concerning going to the movies quickly turned into an argument about how one person never thinks of the other. The conversation evolved into a fiery disagreement. But, as the mom reflected on the conversation, she quickly spotted how it got off track. It had to do with misunderstanding.

She explained to her daughter that not only were words used out of context (interspersed with misspelled words), but also that there were various areas where words trumped intention. The mother went on to explain that texting doesn't carry tone and does a terrible job of conveying intention. Language requires clarity because of all the additional elements needed to be effective. In other words, one does not need to be a wordsmith to effectively communicate—one simply needs to be attentive and responsive. The mom then helped her daughter clarify her thoughts and intentions. She suggested that they speak in person or over a phone call to better convey their feelings and resolve the misunderstanding.

Through this clear and thoughtful communication, the mother was able to diffuse the disagreement. The two girls talked it out, understood each other's perspectives, and reconciled. They not only resolved their conflict but also strengthened their friendship and went on to enjoy the movie together.

How can you and I ensure that we communicate with clarity?

FIVE PRACTICAL STEPS TO HELP WITH CLARITY IN COMMUNICATION

1. Think Before You Speak:
James 1:19 - "My dear brothers and sisters, take note of this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak and slow to become angry."
Take a moment to gather your thoughts before speaking. This helps ensure that your words are clear and well-considered.

2. Use Simple and Direct Language:
Proverbs 15:1 - "A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger."
Avoid jargon or complex vocabulary. Speak plainly and directly to ensure your message is understood.

3. Clarify and Confirm Understanding:
Proverbs 4:7 - "The beginning of wisdom is this: Get wisdom. Though it cost all you have, get understanding."
After communicating, ask questions to confirm that the listener has understood your message correctly.

4. Be Mindful of Non-Verbal Cues:
Proverbs 25:11 - "A word fitly spoken is like apples of gold in settings of silver."
Pay attention to body language, facial expressions, and tone of voice, as these can greatly impact the clarity of your message.

5. Practice Active Listening:
Philippians 2:4 - "Let each of you look not only to his own interests but also to the interests of others."
Focus on listening more than speaking. Show that you are engaged and interested in understanding the other person.

KEY CONCEPTS

- **The Importance of Clear and Precise Communication**
  - Clear communication is essential for effective interactions. It ensures that the message is understood as intended.
- **Avoiding Ambiguity**
  - Ambiguity can lead to misunderstandings and conflict. Strive to be precise and unambiguous in your communication.

OBJECT LESSONS

- **The Telephone Game**
  - Have participants play the telephone game to illustrate how easily messages can become distorted. This highlights the importance of clear and accurate communication.
- **Clarity Challenge**
  - Give participants a complex idea or concept and ask them to explain it in simple terms. This exercise helps develop the skill of simplifying complex ideas.

TECHNIQUES

- **Simplifying Complex Ideas**
  - Practice breaking down complex ideas into simpler, more understandable parts. Use analogies or examples to aid comprehension.
- **Active Listening to Ensure Understanding**
  - Encourage participants to practice active listening by summarizing what they have heard and asking clarifying questions. This helps ensure that the message has been accurately received

EXTERNAL SOURCE

"The single biggest problem in communication is the illusion that it has taken place"
- George Bernard Shaw

WEEK 4

SPEAKING WITH GRACE

Biblical Principle

"Let your conversation be always full of grace, seasoned with salt, so that you may know how to answer everyone."
~ Colossians 4:6

Introduction

Perhaps one of the most difficult realities concerning communication not only as a leader but as a christian is to truly practice treating others as we ought to be treated, not as we are being treated.

The Grace of Saint Stephen

In the early days of the Christian church, persecution was rampant. Among the first to face the ultimate test of faith was Saint Stephen, a man full of faith and the Holy Spirit. Chosen as one of the seven deacons to serve the early Christian community, Stephen was known for his powerful preaching and miraculous works, which drew the ire of the Jewish authorities.

Stephen's unwavering commitment to Christ and his bold proclamation of the Gospel led to his arrest and trial before the Sanhedrin, the Jewish ruling council. As false witnesses accused him, Stephen remained composed, filled with divine grace. He responded not with anger or retaliation, but with a profound and courageous speech that recounted Israel's history and pointed to Jesus as the Righteous One.

His words, inspired by the Holy Spirit, cut to the heart of his accusers. Enraged, they dragged Stephen out of the city and began to stone him. In this brutal moment, Stephen's response was not one of bitterness or condemnation. Instead, he embodied the very essence of Christlike grace. As the stones rained down upon him, Stephen prayed, "Lord Jesus, receive my spirit." Then, echoing the words of Jesus on the cross, he cried out, "Lord, do not hold this sin against them" (Acts 7:59-60, ESV).

Stephen's final words were a profound act of grace and forgiveness, treating his executioners with a mercy they did not show him. His martyrdom serves as a compelling testament to the power of speaking with grace, even in the face of extreme adversity. Stephen’s example challenges us to reflect Christ’s love and mercy in our interactions, demonstrating the profound impact of gracious speech.

As we dive into this week's lesson on "Speaking with Grace," let us draw inspiration from Saint Stephen. His ability to extend grace and forgiveness, even in the direst of circumstances, exemplifies the call to speak to others not merely as they treat us but as Christ would have us treat them. Our words hold the power to heal, uplift, and reflect the love of Jesus, making "Speaking with Grace" an essential practice for every Christian leader.

KEY COMPONENTS OF GRACE-FILLED SPEECH

1. BALANCING TRUTH WITH LOVE

”Instead, speaking the truth in love, we will grow to become in every respect the mature body of him who is the head, that is, Christ”
~ Ephesians 4:15 NIV

Practical Application - When sharing truth, ensure it is wrapped in love. Consider the person’s feelings and approach them with empathy. This means not shying away from hard truths but delivering them in a way that the person can receive without feeling attacked or belittled.

2. CONTROLLING THE TONGUE

Scripture Reference: "Those who guard their mouths and their tongues keep themselves from calamity" ~ Proverbs 21:23 NIV

Practical Application: Practice self-control by pausing before speaking, especially in emotionally charged situations. This pause allows time to consider the impact of your words and choose a response that reflects Christlike grace.

3. Pausing and Thinking Before Responding
"Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak and slow to become angry" ~ James 1:19 NIV

Practical Application: Develop the habit of listening more and speaking less. Before responding, take a deep breath, pray for wisdom, and then respond thoughtfully rather than reacting impulsively.

4. Treating People Not as They Deserve, but as They Need
"But love your enemies, do good to them, and lend to them without expecting to get anything back. Then your reward will be great, and you will be children of the Most High, because he is kind to the ungrateful and wicked" ~ Luke 6:35 NIV

Practical Application: Approach every interaction with the mindset of grace. Even when others are difficult or undeserving, choose to respond with kindness and understanding. Consider what they might be going through and offer compassion instead of judgment.

5. Dealing with Difficult People
"A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger" ~ Proverbs 15:1 NIV

Practical Application: When faced with difficult individuals, use de-escalation techniques such as speaking softly, maintaining a calm demeanor, and expressing empathy. Aim to defuse tension rather than escalate conflict, demonstrating the peace and patience of Christ in your interactions.

TECHNIQUES FOR GRACE-FILLED SPEECH

USING KIND AND GENTLE WORDS
"Let your conversation be always full of grace, seasoned with salt, so that you may know how to answer everyone" (Colossians 4:6, NIV).

Practical Application: Make a conscious effort to use words that build up rather than tear down. This includes offering compliments, expressing gratitude, and providing constructive feedback with kindness.

RESPONDING RATHER THAN REACTING
"Do not be quickly provoked in your spirit, for anger resides in the lap of fools" (Ecclesiastes 7:9).

Practical Application: Train yourself to pause and consider your response, especially in challenging situations. This might mean counting to ten, taking a few deep breaths, or saying a quick prayer before speaking.

EXTERNAL SOURCE

Contemporary Christian leader and author, Dr. Charles Stanley, emphasizes the importance of grace-filled communication: "Our words should be a reflection of our relationship with Christ. They have the power to build up or tear down, to encourage or discourage. Speak with grace, as if the Lord Himself were speaking through you" (Stanley, Charles. "The Power of Speaking God's Word").

CONCLUSION

Grace-filled speech is not only a biblical mandate, but a powerful tool for Christian leaders, allowing us to reflect the love and character of Christ in our interactions. By balancing truth with love, controlling our tongues, pausing before responding, treating others with grace, and de-escalating conflict, we can communicate in a way that honors God and edifies others. Let us commit to speaking with grace, ensuring that our words are always a source of light and encouragement to those around us.

WEEK 5

INFLUENCE THROUGH INTEGRITY

Biblical Principle

"The Lord detests lying lips, but he delights in people who are trustworthy."
~ Proverbs 12:22

Introduction

"You are not ignorant for not knowing; you are ignorant for not knowing that you do not know."

Picture this - Jim, a well-meaning but somewhat overconfident guy, lands a new job in an IT department. On his first day, Jim's boss asks if he knows how to configure a server. Jim, not wanting to seem unqualified, confidently replies, "Of course!"

Reality check—Jim's IT knowledge is limited to turning his computer on and off. Determined to save face, he heads to the server room, which looks more like a scene from a sci-fi movie than anything he's familiar with. He starts poking around, pushing buttons, and muttering technical jargon he once heard in a movie.

Minutes later, the office lights flicker, all computers go blank, and the company's entire network crashes. Panicking, Jim's attempts to "fix" things only make matters worse. By the end of the day, the IT department is in chaos, and it's clear to everyone that Jim's expertise was, well, exaggerated.

Jim's little white lie, meant to impress his boss, resulted in a major fiasco, damaging not only the company's operations but also his credibility. It's a humorous scenario, but the lesson is clear: falsely representing yourself might seem harmless at first, but it can quickly lead to significant consequences.

KEY COMPONENTS OF INFLUENCE THROUGH INTEGRITY

1. Honesty and Transparency

"The Lord detests lying lips, but he delights in people who are trustworthy" ~Proverbs 12:22 NIV

Practical Application: Always be truthful about your abilities and knowledge. It's better to admit what you don't know and seek help than to pretend and risk greater harm. Honest communication builds trust and respect.

2. Consistency in Words and Actions

"Whoever walks in integrity walks securely, but whoever takes crooked paths will be found out" ~ Proverbs 10:9, NIV

Practical Application: Ensure that your actions align with your words. Consistency is key to maintaining integrity. If you promise something, follow through. If you make a mistake, own up to it and correct it.

3. Accountability

"Therefore, each of you must put off falsehood and speak truthfully to your neighbor, for we are all members of one body" ~ Ephesians 4:25, NIV

Practical Application: Surround yourself with people who will hold you accountable. Seek feedback and be open to constructive criticism. Accountability helps you stay true to your values and commitments.

4. Humility and Teachability

"When pride comes, then comes disgrace, but with humility comes wisdom" ~ Proverbs 11:2, NIV

Practical Application: Be humble enough to admit when you don't know something and willing to learn. A teachable spirit not only prevents you from overstepping your knowledge but also endears you to others as someone who values growth and improvement.

5. Respecting Others' Trust

"A good name is more desirable than great riches; to be esteemed is better than silver or gold"
~ Proverbs 22:1, NIV

Practical Application: Value the trust others place in you. Protect your reputation by being reliable and trustworthy. Once lost, trust is hard to regain, so handle it with care.

TECHNIQUES FOR MAINTAINING INTEGRITY

- **Admitting Limitations**
  - "Whoever conceals their sins does not prosper, but the one who confesses and renounces them finds mercy" (Proverbs 28:13, NIV).
  - ***Practical Application:*** When faced with a task beyond your skillset, acknowledge it openly and seek assistance. This shows honesty and a willingness to grow.

- **Building Trust Through Reliability**
  - "Now it is required that those who have been given a trust must prove faithful"
    ~ 1 Corinthians 4:2, NIV
  - ***Practical Application:*** Be someone who can be counted on. Consistently fulfill your commitments, and people will trust you more.

EXTERNAL SOURCE

Renowned Christian author and leadership expert John C. Maxwell emphasizes the importance of integrity: "Image is what people think we are; integrity is what we really are."
(Maxwell, John C. "The 21 Indispensable Qualities of a Leader")

CONCLUSION

Integrity is foundational to effective leadership and genuine influence. By being honest, consistent, accountable, humble, and respectful of others' trust, we can build a legacy of integrity that inspires and influences others positively. Remember Proverbs 12:22: "The Lord detests lying lips, but he delights in people who are trustworthy." Let us strive to be leaders whose integrity shines through in every word and action, making a lasting impact for God's glory.

WEEK 6

THE ART OF LISTENING

Biblical Principle

"My dear brothers and sisters, take note of this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak and slow to become angry." ~ James 1:19

Introduction

"Your crisis cannot be my crisis; otherwise, we will both be in crisis." - Pastor Aaron Rios

Imagine being on a packed flight, thousands of feet above the ground. The cabin is bustling with noise—passengers chatting, babies crying, flight attendants making announcements. Amid the cacophony, a subtle but unusual noise goes unnoticed by most. Everyone is busy complaining about the delays, the lack of legroom, and the mediocre in-flight meal. Except for one passenger. John, an experienced mechanic, is not caught up in the distractions. He listens intently, filtering through the noise. Suddenly, he hears a faint, irregular sound coming from beneath his seat. Recognizing it as a potential mechanical issue, John promptly alerts the flight crew. The crew investigates and discovers a serious problem that, if left unaddressed, could have led to a catastrophic failure. Thanks to John's careful listening and quick action, the issue is resolved, and the flight lands safely. While everyone else was preoccupied with their complaints and distractions, John's ability to listen carefully saved the day.

Consider the impact of active listening. Just as John saved the passengers by tuning into the critical noise amidst the chaos, we too can navigate life's complexities by honing our listening skills. As James 1:19 (NIV) reminds us, "Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak and slow to become angry." By prioritizing listening, we can better understand situations, avoid unnecessary conflicts, and respond more effectively.

KEY CONCEPTS OF ACTIVE LISTENING

1. The Importance of Active Listening

"Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak and slow to become angry" (James 1:19, NIV).

Practical Application: Prioritize listening in conversations. By giving full attention to the speaker, we can understand their perspective and respond thoughtfully. Active listening helps build trust and foster better communication.

2. Understanding Before Being Understood

"To answer before listening—that is folly and shame" (Proverbs 18:13, NIV).

Practical Application: Seek to understand others' viewpoints before sharing your own. This approach demonstrates respect and a genuine interest in the other person's thoughts and feelings, leading to more meaningful interactions.

TECHNIQUES FOR EFFECTIVE LISTENING

1. Reflective Listening: Paraphrasing and Summarizing

"The purposes of a person's heart are deep waters, but one who has insight draws them out" (Proverbs 20:5).

Practical Application: After someone speaks, paraphrase their message to ensure you understood correctly. Summarizing helps clarify the conversation and shows that you value what they are saying. For example, "What I'm hearing is..." or "It sounds like you're saying...".

2. Asking Clarifying Questions

"The one who has knowledge uses words with restraint, and whoever has understanding is even-tempered" (Proverbs 17:27, NIV).

Practical Application: When in doubt, ask questions to gain a deeper understanding. Questions like “Can you explain more about that?” or “What do you mean by…?” demonstrate your commitment to truly understanding the speaker.

EXTERNAL SOURCE

Stephen Covey, in his seminal work "The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People," emphasizes, "Seek first to understand, then to be understood." This principle underlines the importance of empathetic listening as a foundational skill for effective communication and leadership.

CONCLUSION

Active listening is a crucial skill for any leader. By being quick to listen and slow to speak, we can foster better relationships, make wiser decisions, and handle conflicts more effectively. Remember, "Your crisis cannot be my crisis; otherwise, we will both be in crisis." Let us embrace the wisdom of James 1:19 and commit to listening actively, understanding others, and responding with grace and insight.

WEEK 7

LEADING WITH VISION

Biblical Principle

"Then the Lord replied: 'Write down the revelation and make it plain on tablets so that a herald may run with it.'" ~ Habakkuk 2:2

Introduction

Imagine standing at the edge of a vast, uncharted wilderness. You have a clear mental picture of a flourishing city that could rise from this untamed land—a city of hope, prosperity, and unity. Yet, as long as this vision remains in your mind, it is intangible and untouchable. It exists only in the realm of thought, unseen by others.

Now, envision yourself taking this mental picture and sketching it out on a map. You draw the streets, the buildings, the parks, and the public squares. This act of putting pen to paper transforms your vision from an abstract idea into a tangible plan that others can see and grasp. The sketch becomes a blueprint that guides the construction workers, city planners, and citizens as they work together to bring this vision to life.

There is power in writing down a vision; don't trust your memory to maintain inspiriation. Inspiration is fleeting and comes in moments, and when its gone its gone. Good leaders have learned to journal. In Habakkuk 2:2, the Lord instructs the prophet to write down the revelation and make it plain on tablets so that a herald may run with it. By committing the vision to writing, Habakkuk took it out of the unseen spiritual realm and made it tangible and actionable. This is a biblically sound principle that underscores the importance of clarity and communication in leadership.

KEY CONCEPTS OF LEADING WITH VISION

1. Communicating Vision Clearly and Compellingly

"Write down the revelation and make it plain on tablets so that a herald may run with it" (Habakkuk 2:2, NIV).

Practical Application: When you have a vision, articulate it clearly and compellingly. Break it down into understandable and actionable steps that can inspire and guide others. A well-communicated vision serves as a roadmap that everyone can follow.

2. Inspiring Others to Action

"Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he" (Proverbs 29:18, KJV).

Practical Application: A compelling vision motivates and inspires people to act. Share your vision with passion and enthusiasm, highlighting the benefits and impact it will have. When people see the value and potential of the vision, they are more likely to commit to it and work towards its realization.

TECHNIQUES FOR EFFECTIVE VISION CASTING

- **Crafting and Sharing a Compelling Vision Statement**

"The plans of the diligent lead to profit as surely as haste leads to poverty" (Proverbs 21:5, NIV).

  - **Practical Application:** Develop a clear and concise vision statement that encapsulates your goals and aspirations. Share this statement consistently in meetings, sermons, and communications to keep everyone aligned and focused on the common goal.

- **Using Storytelling to Convey Vision**

"Jesus spoke all these things to the crowd in parables; he did not say anything to them without using a parable" (Matthew 13:34, NIV).

  - **Practical Application:** Leverage the power of storytelling to make your vision relatable and memorable. Share stories that illustrate the potential impact of the vision, drawing on real-life examples, biblical narratives, and personal experiences to make the vision come alive.

EXTERNAL SOURCE

Rick Warren, in "The Purpose Driven Church," emphasizes the importance of vision casting: "Vision is the ability to see the opportunities within your current circumstances. It's about seeing the potential in your situation and inspiring others to work toward it."

CONCLUSION

Leading with vision requires clarity, communication, and inspiration. By writing down your vision and sharing it compellingly, you can transform abstract ideas into tangible realities that inspire and mobilize others. Remember Habakkuk 2:2: "Write down the revelation and make it plain on tablets so that a herald may run with it." Let us commit to leading with vision, crafting clear and compelling statements, and using storytelling to convey the impact and potential of our God-given dreams.

WEEK 8

ENCOURAGEMENT AND EMPOWERMENT

Biblical Principle

“Therefore encourage one another and build each other up, just as in fact you are doing."
~ 1 Thessalonians 5:11

Introduction

Imagine for a moment that you’re sitting in a grand theater, the kind with rich velvet seats and golden trim. The stage is set, the lights are dimmed, and the audience is abuzz with anticipation. As the curtains rise, the spotlight illuminates a group of leaders who have been on a transformative journey over the past eight weeks. These leaders began as individual students, each with their own strengths, challenges, and dreams. Over the course of this journey, they’ve engaged deeply with the principles of effective leadership—understanding unity, embracing integrity, communicating with grace, and most importantly, encouraging and empowering one another.

As the story unfolds on stage, a charismatic leader steps forward, representing each of you who have embarked on this journey. With a powerful and uplifting voice, they recount the incredible transformations witnessed during these eight weeks. They talk about how encouragement, even in its smallest forms, has sparked significant change.

They recall the powerful moments when a word of encouragement helped someone overcome their self-doubt, or how recognizing a small achievement led to a surge of confidence. The audience is moved by how each person’s growth has been fueled by the collective support and positive reinforcement of the group.

Then, the leader turns to the audience—breaking the fourth wall—and directly addresses you, the reader. "You," they say with heartfelt sincerity, "are the unsung heroes of this journey. Your dedication, your willingness to encourage, and your support have made all the difference. As you move forward, remember the impact of your words and actions. You have the power to build up and uplift those around you. Just as you’ve been encouraged and empowered, go out and extend that same grace to others."

The story concludes with a vibrant display of applause and cheers, symbolizing the celebration of each person's progress and the collective achievement of the group. The message is clear: encouragement and empowerment are not just principles learned but practices to be lived out every day.

KEY CONCEPTS OF ENCOURAGEMENT AND EMPOWERMENT

The Role of Encouragement in Leadership

"Therefore encourage one another and build each other up, just as in fact you are doing"
(1 Thessalonians 5:11, NIV).

***Practical Application*:** As leaders, your role is to uplift and motivate those around you. Encourage your team members, recognize their efforts, and provide support. This positive reinforcement helps them grow and succeed, creating a more productive and harmonious environment.

Empowering Others Through Words

"The tongue has the power of life and death, and those who love it will eat its fruit"
(Proverbs 18:21, NIV).

Practical Application: Use your words to inspire and empower others. Speak life into their potential, affirm their abilities, and offer constructive feedback that fosters growth. Your encouragement can ignite their confidence and drive.

TECHNIQUES FOR ENCOURAGEMENT AND EMPOWERMENT

- **Offering Constructive Feedback**

"The way of fools seems right to them, but the wise listen to advice" (Proverbs 12:15, NIV).

  - ***Practical Application:*** Provide feedback that is both honest and supportive. Focus on what can be improved while also acknowledging what is already being done well. This balanced approach helps individuals understand their strengths and areas for growth without feeling discouraged.

- **Recognizing and Celebrating Others' Achievements**

"Rejoice with those who rejoice; mourn with those who mourn" (Romans 12:15, NIV).

  - ***Practical Application:*** Take time to celebrate milestones and achievements, no matter how small. Publicly recognizing and praising someone's hard work boosts their morale and motivates them to continue striving for excellence.

EXTERNAL SOURCE

Joel Osteen, in his teachings, emphasizes the power of encouragement: "Encouragement is the fuel that helps people become who they were created to be. It's the spark that ignites the passion and drive within them" (Osteen, Joel. "Your Best Life Now").

CONCLUSION

As we conclude this eight-week journey, remember the power of encouragement and empowerment. Just as you have been uplifted and inspired, go forth and extend that same grace to others. Your words and actions can build up, empower, and transform lives. Embrace the call of 1 Thessalonians 5:11 to encourage and build each other up, and let your leadership be a beacon of hope and inspiration.

Garden City Church

Live the life. Tell the story

Garden City Church
www.gardencitychurch.net
© Aaron Rios 2024